

diplomacy the year of confrontation

The nuclear **SHADOW**

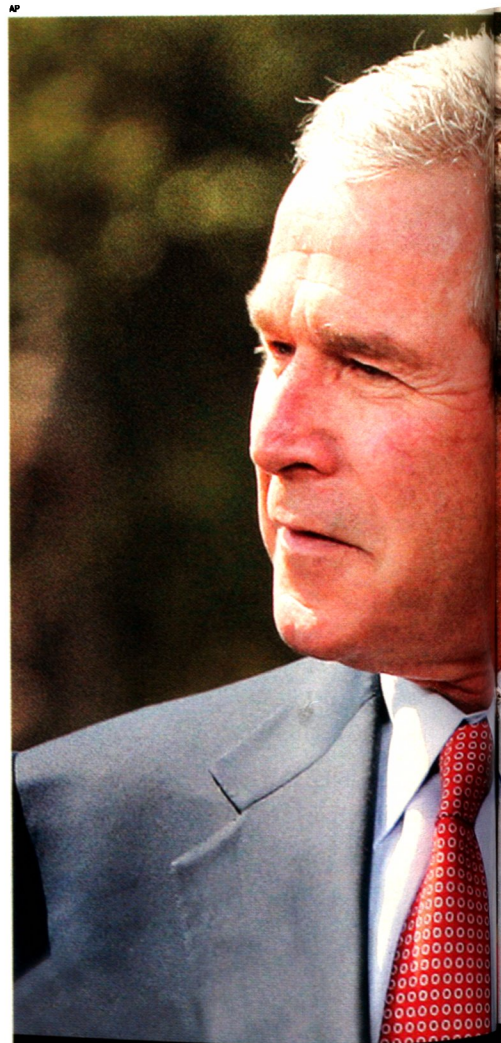
A debilitating battle with the Left and the Parliament over its bold civilian nuclear deal with the US tests the art of blinkmanship and puts foreign policy in doldrums

■ By Raj Chengappa

It should have been the best of years for Indian foreign policy and for the Manmohan Singh Government. After all by mid-2007, the Government seemed to have pulled off a coup of sorts by signing the 123 bilateral agreement that should have all but sealed the Indo-US civilian nuclear deal. Now all that India had to do was to work out an India-specific safeguards agreement with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). Then, it was to sit back and watch US President George Bush and his Government do the rest. This included persuading the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) to allow its 45 members to do civilian nuclear trade with India apart from getting the US Congress to ratify the 123 Agreement. By the end of 2007, the deal described "as a historic breakthrough" was to transform relations between the world's most populous democracy and its most powerful one.

Meanwhile, India was to take major steps to move the peace process with Pakistan significantly forward. Manmohan was to make a triumphant visit to his birthplace, Gah, in Pakistan, which had been spruced up by funds that had been hurriedly pumped in for its development. There was a hint of a 'breakthrough' (the much-abused word in diplomatic lexicon) on Kashmir as a roadmap for a final settlement was to be agreed upon. With the politics of confrontation engulfing other neighbours like Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Myanmar, India was expected to lend a helping hand to sort out the internal strife. There was also the promise that relations with Russia would be further cemented during the year especially because Moscow had hoped to bag major contracts for selling its nuclear power reactors.

Yet in the end, 2007 turned out to be a nightmarish year for foreign policy for the Manmohan Government. There was confrontation over the deal not just with its allies but in Parliament where



What should have been Manmohan's survival as the Left parties unleash